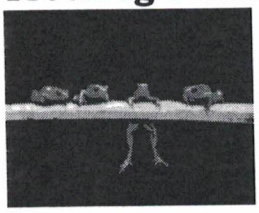
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APPROPRIATE DIET FOR A PET

By Brian Weilert

Author's note: The gender of either one or both of the characters in this piece can be altered by making the following changes:

Replace : *Tiger* with *Angel*
Stephen with *Stephanie*
All gender references (*Dad-Mom, son-daughter, boy-girl, etc*)
Some other cutting may be necessary

TEASER:

Boy: My dog, Barf, has….well….he has a weight problem and unless something changes in his eating habits….Well, I just don't see him magically getting smaller.

Dad: My son, Stephen, has…well….he has a weight problem and unless something changes in his eating habits…Well, I just don't see him magically getting smaller.

Boy: You see Barf…
Dad: ...Stephen is basically…
Boy: …a great dog….
Dad: ...boy, but he just can't seem…
Boy: …to be able to deal with…
Dad: …the death of his mother…
Boy: …the loss of his favorite toy…
Both: …and so he eats.

END TEASER

Boy: Hey Dad, what's up?
Dad: What's with all the noise Tiger? It's like 3:00 in the morning.
Boy: Yeah, I know but Barf was hungry.
Dad: Really, where is he?
Boy: *(Looking around)* Oh, don't know he was just here. Must of ran off when you came down the stairs.
Dad: That pie for him?

Boy: This pie? Ummmm…yes…I mean no… it's for me.
Dad: That's one big piece for such a young boy.
Boy: Yeah, just hungry….kind of….I think.
Dad: What'd you say we if we just put the pie away until morning?
Boy: What about Barf? He's hungry. He might starve.
Dad: Have you seen Barf lately? I'm thinking he's going to make it.
Boy: Yeah, I'm kind of worried about his eating and all, you know what I mean?
Dad: I think I do Tiger.
Boy: Just not the same since he lost his ball. He really loved it, you know?
Dad: I do.
Boy: Can I sleep with you tonight?
Dad: Sure, I think I can make room.
Boy: I guess I can save the pie for breakfast.
Dad: We'll just have to wait as see about that. Come on, let's get to bed.

Scene

Boy: Barf has been digging in the trash a lot lately. He used to never do it, but it seems like he just can't help himself. He is always right in my face every time I eat even if I just fed him. And the moment I open the fridge for a snack he's lacing himself in and out between my legs. It is starting to really get annoying. I would hit him or something but his eyes look so sad when I raise my voice….I just can't.

Dad: Stephen's been getting into the fridge a lot lately. He used to never do it, but it seems like he just can't help himself. He's always right in my face every time I grab a snack, even if he just ate. And when I go to the kitchen, I find myself tripping over him. It's starting to bother me but I'm afraid to say anything. I just don't think he can handle anything else right now.

Scene

Boy: Dad?! Dad?! Come here quick! Look at Barf. *(Laughing)* He's trying to get up on the bed but he's too fat.
Dad: He sure is. What do you think we ought to do to help him?
Boy: I could go give him a push.
Dad: I mean about his eating.
Boy: Oh, I never really thought about it. He is just so sad about his toy and all. Maybe he just needs some time to get over it. Then maybe he'll stop eating on his own.
Dad: You think that's what we need to do, just give him a little time?
Boy: Yeah.
Dad: How much time you think before we step in, before we help the old boy out?
Boy: Maybe a month or so? Yeah, that sounds about right?

Dad: That's a pretty long time. If he keeps up his present pace he won't be able to walk by then; his belly will hang lower than his legs can reach.
Boy: I think he needs the time Dad.
Dad: Okay, but I may not be able to wait that long, you understand?
Boy: Yeah.

Scene

Boy: Barf, you have dad worried. *(Pause)* I have to be honest, I'm a little concerned too. You know life has to go on. You just can't keep eating, it's not going to make things better and well... look at you. *(Getting sad)* I know you miss your toy… I know it was your whole life and you loved it more than anything in the whole wide world *(Sadder)* and it's not fair...but... *(Pause)* Hey, what do you say we go to the kitchen and see what we can rustle up?

Dad: I'm really worried. I know he misses his mother; I miss my wife but life has to go on. Eating isn't going to heal his pain. He's getting so obese, I am afraid he not going to regain control. *(Act as if hearing noise)* That's got to be him in the kitchen.

Scene

Boy: *(Crying)* Dad?
Dad: What's a matter Tiger?
Boy: They called me fattso.
Dad: Who called you that?
Boy: Some of the kids at school. They called me fattso and said I need a bra.
Dad: *(Angry)* Who were they? What were their names?
Boy: No Dad, it will only make things worse.
Dad: Well, did you say anything back? What you do? *(Pause)* Well?....
Boy: I screamed, MY MOM IS DEAD!! *(Crying again)*
Dad: *(Hugging him)* Oh, buddy I'm sorry, I so sorry.
Boy: Why Dad, why did God steal her?
Dad: I don't know son. I really don't know.

Scene

Boy: You are a total fattso, you know that? Bad dog! You need to quit eating and I don't care if you're sad or not. You're disgusting and you have no one to blame but yourself! Eating all that stuff ain't going to bring back your stupid toy! Grow up! And I don't want to hear your whining.

Dad: Fattso, as mad as it made me to hear them call him that, I've thought the same type of things. I don't know if I should give him tough love and just tell him he has no one to blame but himself. That he can shove his mouth full until the cows come home and it still isn't going to bring his mom back. To just Grow up and quit crying!

Scene

Dad: *(concerned)* What's that there in you pocket Tiger?
Boy: Nothin'.
Dad: That's an aweful big and bulky nothin'. *(pause)* What's in there?
Boy: *(Raising his voice)* I said nothing!
Dad: *(Raising voice)* Don't lie to me Stephen! Let me see!
Boy: Mind your own business!
Dad: *(Losing it)* What did you say to me?!
Boy: Just leave me alone *(turns to leave)*
Dad: *(Grabs him and tries to take object from his pocket. A real struggle ensues, screaming, kicking, until the Dad finally gets it free. He stands stunned as he holds a bottle of pills in his hand)* My God….where'd you get these?
Boy: *(silence)*
Dad: *(trying to sound calm)* I asked you a question Stephen; where did you get these?
Boy: They're Mom's.
Dad: I know that, but where? We threw all these away.
Boy: I hid 'em after she died.
Dad: Do you know what they are?
Boy: They're what mom took so she wouldn't have to be around me any more.
Dad: *(stunned)* What?
Boy: They're the pills mom took so …
Dad: *(interrupting as if not hearing what his son is saying*) Why did you hide them?
Boy: So you wouldn't leave me too.
Dad: *(hugging his child)* I would never leave you Tiger. I love you more than…
Both: …all the leaves on the trees.
Boy: Yeah, that's what mom used to say.
Dad: You're mother, she loved you very much. You have to know that. She was…she was just sick, that's all….just sick.
Boy: I hate her.
Dad: What she did was wrong but it had nothing to do with you. *(holding his shoulders and looking directly into Stephen's eyes)* Do you understand me?
Boy: I'm trying dad.
Dad: Tiger, why'd YOU have the pills today?
Boy: I was….I was….going to give them to Barf. He's just too sad. I think it would be easier for him this way.

Dad: *(holding up pills)* These aren't the answer for anyone. They weren't for your mother, they aren't for Barf…..*(pause)* and not for you either buddy. Look, life hurts sometimes but we must keep on surviving. I miss your mom too, every day and God knows not a day goes by that I don't feel some guilt about her decision…but Tiger, we have to go on. You, me, and Barf are a family. Do you hear me? We will survive.

Boy: *(hugging his father)* I'm so sorry dad. I love you.

Dad: I'm sorry too. I love you.

Scene

Boy: *(to dog)* Barf, we're survivors. I know you miss your ball but it isn't your fault. You got to believe it. Sometimes life just hurts but I love you and we're a family.

Dad: Stephen and I cried a lot but we talk a lot too…about forgiving our guilt and surviving our pain. We talked about our love for one another and how we still are a family.

Scene

Dad: Missed you at breakfast this morning, you feeling ok.

Boy: Yeah, I just wasn't hungry so Barf and I went for a walk instead.

Dad: Really?

Boy: Yeah, he about died of a heart attack though.

Dad: How about you? How'd you fair?

Boy: I'll be honest. I was pretty tired.

Dad: I bet. *(pause)* You want something now?

Boy: Yeah, a bowl of cereal would be ok.

Dad: I'll get it. *(pause)* What about Barf?

Boy: He'll have the same.

Dad: *(pulling a ball from his pocket)* Hey Tiger?

Boy: Yeah?

Dad: *(tossing ball)* Thought you and Barf might be wanting to play after you eat.

Boy: Thanks dad…*(pause)* Barf says he loves you.

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